

Business Plan: Horse Cart Tourist Experience in Rosendal

Executive Summary

This business will offer scenic horse cart rides and traditional countryside experiences for tourists visiting Rosendal and the Eastern Free State region. The service will target weekend travelers, families, photographers, couples, wedding groups, and tourists looking for authentic rural experiences.

Rosendal has become known as an arts village and peaceful tourism destination with growing visitor numbers, guesthouses, hiking, mountain biking, and horse-related tourism activities.

The business will generate income through:

- Horse cart rides
- Sunset tours
- Wedding transport
- Photography packages
- School and family outings
- Farm experience packages

1. Business Overview

Business Name

Rosendal Horse Cart Tours

Location

Rosendal

Business Type

Tourism and leisure transport business

Vision

To become one of the top rural tourism attractions in the Eastern Free State by offering safe, memorable, and authentic horse cart experiences.

Mission

To promote local tourism, create jobs, and preserve traditional horse-cart heritage while providing unique experiences for visitors.

2. Market Opportunity

Rosendal attracts tourists because of:

- Scenic mountain views
- Art galleries and restaurants
- Hiking and cycling trails
- Peaceful countryside atmosphere
- Weekend tourism from Johannesburg, Bloemfontein, and Gauteng

Tourism authorities identify the Eastern Free State as a growing adventure and heritage tourism destination, including horse riding and rural activities.

The area already attracts visitors interested in:

- Horse riding
- Nature tourism
- Farm stays
- Photography
- Heritage experiences

A horse cart business fits naturally into this tourism market.

3. Services Offered

Core Services

Village Horse Cart Ride

- 30–45 minute guided ride through Rosendal
- Historical storytelling
- Photo stops

Price:

- R150–R250 per person

Sunset Mountain Ride

- Scenic evening ride outside town
- Includes refreshments

Price:

- R350–R500 per person

Wedding & Event Transport

- Bridal entrance
- Romantic couple rides
- Festival transport

Price:

- R1,500–R5,000 per event

Family Farm Experience

- Horse cart ride
- Farm animal interaction
- Picnic option

Price:

- R300–R700 per family

School Tours

- Educational rides
- Farm history and horse care demonstrations

Price:

- Group rates available

4. Target Market

Primary Customers

- Domestic tourists

- Weekend visitors
- Families
- Couples
- Wedding planners
- Guesthouses and lodges

Secondary Customers

- Schools
- Corporate retreats
- International tourists

5. Competitive Advantage

Unique Selling Points

- Authentic old-style Free State experience
- Scenic mountain environment
- Eco-friendly tourism activity
- Family-friendly attraction
- Cultural storytelling
- Instagram/photo-friendly experience

Rosendal is marketed as a peaceful and scenic tourism destination with growing popularity among photographers, artists, and weekend tourists.

6. Startup Requirements

Equipment Needed

Item

Estimated Cost

Horse cart/wagon

R25,000 – R80,000

2 trained horses

R20,000 – R60,000

Harnesses & tack

R10,000

Stable & fencing

R15,000

Insurance

R5,000

Branding/signage

R5,000

Marketing setup

R5,000

Licenses/permits

R5,000

Emergency & veterinary fund

R10,000

Estimated Startup Capital

Total: R100,000 – R250,000

7. Operations Plan

Daily Operations

- Morning and afternoon rides
- Weekend-focused tourism schedule
- Booking system via WhatsApp and Facebook

Staffing

Initially owner-operated with:

- 1 horse handler/assistant
- Part-time guide

Future expansion:

- Additional carts
- Tour guides
- Event coordinator

8. Marketing Strategy

Online Marketing

Create pages on:

- Facebook
- Instagram
- TikTok
- Google Business Profile

Use photos and videos of:

- Scenic rides
- Horses
- Sunsets
- Tourists enjoying experiences

Partnerships

Partner with:

- Guesthouses
- Restaurants
- Wedding venues
- Tourism offices
- Hiking and cycling businesses

Potential nearby tourism attractions already promote horse-related tourism in the region.

9. Financial Projections

Example Monthly Revenue

Income Source

Monthly Estimate

Weekend rides

R12,000

Sunset tours

R8,000

Weddings/events

R10,000

School/family tours

R5,000

Estimated Monthly Revenue

= R35,000

Monthly Expenses

Expense

Monthly Estimate

Horse feed

R4,000

Veterinary care

R2,000

Staff wages

R6,000

Marketing

R1,500

Maintenance

R2,000

Fuel/transport

R1,500

Estimated Monthly Expenses

= R17,000

Estimated Profit

Approx. R18,000 per month initially

Peak tourist seasons and weddings could significantly increase income.

10. Risk Analysis

Risk

Solution

Bad weather

Offer covered wagon rides

Horse illness

Veterinary agreements

Low tourist seasons

School and local packages

Road conditions

Operate mainly within scenic local routes

Road infrastructure challenges in the area can affect tourism access, especially via the R70 route.

11. Growth Opportunities

Future expansion ideas:

- Additional horse carts

- Pony rides for children
- Traditional Free State cultural tours
- Farm accommodation
- Horse riding lessons
- Annual horse cart festival
- Tourism packages with local guesthouses

12. Funding Opportunities

Possible funding sources:

- Small Enterprise Development Agency (SEDA)
- National Youth Development Agency (NYDA)
- Tourism Incentive Programme
- Local municipality tourism support
- Private investors

South Africa's tourism sector, including Free State rural tourism, continues to attract investment opportunities.

Conclusion

A horse cart tourism business in Rosendal has strong potential because the town already attracts visitors seeking peaceful countryside experiences, outdoor activities, and heritage tourism. With relatively low startup costs and strong visual appeal for tourists and social media marketing, the business can become a profitable and sustainable rural tourism attraction.